

JURASSIC ENGLISH™

IELTS Speaking Ladder

Fix the small habits that hold your Speaking score at Band 5–6: one habit per lesson, timed practice for Parts 1, 2 and 3.

Self-study | 18 lessons | Band 5.0 → 7.0 | IELTS Speaking Parts 1–3

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What you get in this pack

Eighteen self-study lessons in three levels. Each lesson fixes one habit that costs marks at Band 5–6, with timed speaking practice and the answer key at the end.

109	**printable A4 pages** This licensed PDF: three levels, with a contents page and every lesson starting on a new page.
18	**self-study lessons** Level 1 (Band 5.0 → 5.5): 7 lessons. Level 2 (Band 5.5 → 6.0): 7 lessons. Level 3 (Band 6.0 → 6.5–7.0): 4 lessons.
18	**answer keys** One at the end of every lesson, so you can check your practice before you move on.
3	**speaking parts in every lesson** Part 1, Part 2 and Part 3 tasks with times, plus a self-check of your own speaking.
5	**editable Google Docs** The same lessons as Docs in the buyer's Drive folder.

All lessons, cue cards, scripts and model answers are written by Jurassic English. No third-party material is included. A 1-to-1 Starter lesson for tutors is available as an add-on.

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Lesson 1 · A, An, The — or Nothing

Every noun is a slot. Three questions tell you what goes in it.

Band 5.0 → 5.5 · 45 minutes · Focus: Articles and zero article in Part 1 and Part 2 · Theme: Work and future jobs

Who this lesson is for: For speakers who leave out articles ('she was Vietnamese teacher'), add them where they do not belong ('a food', 'on the June'), or decide each one from scratch while speaking.

Start here

Some languages have no articles at all, so every 'a', 'an' and 'the' in English is a decision made under time pressure.

Articles are the most frequent small error at Band 5, because every noun is a slot.

Today: one rule in three parts, no long list of exceptions. Then you describe things out loud and count your slots.

You need: A phone to record yourself · A timer · Paper and a pen

Warm up

Answer each question for 30 seconds. Do not worry about articles yet — just talk.

- What can you see in the room you are in now?
- What subjects are you studying, or did you study at school?
- What job would you like to do in the future?

The rule

> ***The rule:*** *A / AN = first time or one of many. THE = second time, the only one, or we both know which. NOTHING = plurals and uncountables in general.*

1. Is this the first time I mention it, or one of many? → a / an.
2. Use 'an' before a vowel sound: an app, an engineer, an hour, an instrument.
3. Have I mentioned it before, is it the only one, or do we both know which one? → the.
4. Am I talking in general, with a plural or an uncountable noun (music, food, maths, clothes)? → nothing.
5. Do not put a / an before an uncountable noun, and do not stack two determiners ('a some').

Not yet	Better
She was Vietnamese teacher.	She was a Vietnamese teacher.
I have never played instrument.	I have never played an instrument.
I like a food from my hometown.	I like food from my hometown.
I won a some medal at school.	I won some medals at school.
My birthday is on the June.	My birthday is in June.

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Not yet	Better
My grandmother gives me a lucky money.	My grandmother gives me lucky money.

Why it matters: The public grammar descriptor for Band 5 asks for basic sentence forms 'with reasonable accuracy'. Articles appear in almost every sentence, so fixing them raises accuracy everywhere at once — and you already get many 'nothing' slots right.

Practice

Write a, an, the — or a dash (—) for nothing. Then say the sentence out loud and say WHY: first time, second time, only one, or in general.

Article doctor

1. She was ___ Vietnamese teacher.
2. I had ___ maths teacher. ___ teacher taught me for three years. (two parts, write both with a slash)
3. I think ___ patience is ___ important quality for a teacher. (two parts, write both with a slash)
4. I study ___ maths, but sometimes I study ___ physics. (two parts, write both with a slash)
5. I often buy ___ clothes through ___ app. (two parts, write both with a slash)
6. I don't have to go to ___ shop.
7. I like ___ Vietnamese music because I can understand ___ words. (two parts, write both with a slash)
8. I have never played ___ instrument.
9. In ___ evening I usually take ___ rest. (two parts, write both with a slash)
10. I buy ___ new food or ___ clothes online. (two parts, write both with a slash)

Three slots: a special day

11. My family always cooks ___ big meal on that day.
12. We usually visit ___ house of my grandparents.
13. I like ___ traditional food more than modern food.
14. She gave me ___ present I still keep.
15. It is ___ very important day for my family.
16. In my country ___ people celebrate for three days.
17. My mother makes ___ cake every year.
18. ___ street near my house is full of flowers.
19. I never eat ___ meat on that morning.
20. He is ___ only person who remembers the old songs.

Room tour

First, describe the room you are in to a friend on the phone: say each thing, then say something about it. Then fix three sentences Band 5 learners commonly say.

21. Describe five things in your room: a door, a window, a table, chairs, a light.
22. Say it better: 'I eat a food from my hometown every week.'
23. Say it better: 'My birthday is on the June.'
24. Say it better: 'At New Year my grandmother sends me a lucky money.'

Talk for 60 seconds

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Speak for one minute. Afterwards, list five nouns you used with their articles: a window · the window · chairs …

Timer: 60 seconds each.

25. My room
26. My street
27. A job I would like to do

Upgrade the answer

Part 2: a job you would like to do. Read both out loud. Count the article slots in the strong answer.

Weaker answer: In future, I would like to be software engineer. Software engineer is person who writes programs for the computers and the phones. Every day, engineer sits at desk, talks with team and fixes problems in code. I like this job because salary is good. For example, last year I made small game on my phone. Game was very simple, but my friends played it.

Stronger answer: That's a good question. In the future, I would like to be a software engineer. A software engineer is a person who writes programs for computers and phones. Every day, the engineer sits at a desk, talks with the team and fixes problems in the code. I would like this job for two reasons. First, the salary is good, so I can help my family. Second, I like solving problems. For example, last year I made a small game on my phone. The game was very simple, but my friends played it.

- First mentions take a / an: a software engineer, a desk, a small game.
- Second mentions and things we both know take the: the engineer, the team, the game, the salary.
- General plurals and uncountables take nothing: computers, phones, problems.
- The sentences are simple, but the articles are right — that is what accuracy at this level sounds like.

Speaking Part 1

Record yourself. Listen for 'in the evening' and 'an instrument' type slots.

- When do you usually listen to music?
- Do you play a musical instrument?
- What subjects are you studying now?
- Do you prefer studying in the morning or in the evening?
- What can you see from your window at home?
- Is there a shop near your home that you like?

Answer frame: Answer → Reason (because…) → Example (for example…). Check: first time, second time, only one, or in general?

Speaking Part 2

> ***Describe a job you would like to do in the future.***
>
> *You should say:*
>
> - *what the job is*
> - *what a person does in this job*
> - *what skills you need for it*

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> *and explain why you would like to do this job.*

Plan: One minute: write words only in a box, not sentences. Speak for two minutes (Run A). Listen back and count article slots right and wrong. Then speak again (Run B) and try to beat Run A.

Speaking Part 3

General ideas often need NO article: people, jobs, money, skills.

- Do many people in your country want this kind of job?
- Is it difficult to get a good job these days?
- What skills will be most important for jobs in the future?
- Should schools teach students about different jobs?

Moves: Answer (Your view in one sentence.) → Reason (Because… Watch the general nouns: people, money, skills.) → Example (For example, a friend of mine… then 'my friend' or 'he'.) → Counterpoint (Actually, some people think…)

Check your own speaking

Record one answer, listen back, count.

- ☐ Did every singular countable noun have a / an / the (or my, this, etc.)?
- ☐ Did I switch from a / an to the when I mentioned something again?
- ☐ Did I avoid a / an with uncountable nouns like food, music, money?
- ☐ Did I say any phrase twice in a row?

Count: Article slots right ÷ all article slots (a / an / the / nothing).

Finish and review

You can now:

- I can choose a / an, the or nothing and say why.
- I can switch from a to the on the second mention.
- I can leave out the article for general plurals and uncountables.
- I can count my own article slots on a recording.

Next:

- Record 60 seconds on 'My room' or 'My street'. Write the five nouns you used with their articles.
- Before you speak, ask the three questions: first time? we both know? in general?
- Run Part 2 twice (Run A, Run B) on a new card and compare your article counts.

Answer key · Lesson 1

Try every item first. Accept any answer with the same meaning for open items.

Article doctor

1. She was a Vietnamese teacher. *(One of many teachers, first mention.)*
2. I had a maths teacher. The teacher taught me for three years. *(First mention, then second mention.)*

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3. I think patience is an important quality for a teacher. *(Uncountable in general, then one of many qualities with a vowel sound.)*
4. I study maths, but sometimes I study physics. *(School subjects in general. Trap: do not add anything.)*
5. I often buy clothes through the app. *(Plural in general, then one app both speakers know.)*
6. I don't have to go to the shop. *(Only one shop is meant, and both speakers know which.)*
7. I like Vietnamese music because I can understand the words. *(Music in general, then specific words: those of that music.)*
8. I have never played an instrument. *(One of many, vowel sound.)*
9. In the evening I usually take a rest. *(A part of every day both speakers know, then one of many.)*
10. I buy new food or clothes online. *(Uncountable and plural, in general. Trap item.)*

Three slots: a special day

11. My family always cooks a big meal on that day. *(One meal, first mention.)*
12. We usually visit the house of my grandparents. *(There is only one house we mean.)*
13. I like traditional food more than modern food. *(Uncountable, in general.)*
14. She gave me the present I still keep. *(Words after this noun tell us exactly which present.)*
15. It is a very important day for my family. *(One of many days.)*
16. In my country people celebrate for three days. *(Plural, in general.)*
17. My mother makes a cake every year. *(One cake, one of many.)*
18. The street near my house is full of flowers. *(We both know which street.)*
19. I never eat meat on that morning. *(Uncountable, in general.)*
20. He is the only person who remembers the old songs. *('only' means just one.)*

Room tour

21. There is a window next to my bed. The window looks out onto the street. There are two chairs, and the door is behind me.
22. I eat food from my hometown every week.
23. My birthday is in June.
24. At New Year my grandmother sends me lucky money.

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Lesson 15 · Agreement Under Load

Keep the -s right inside your longest, best sentences.

Band 6.0 → 6.5–7.0 · 50 minutes · Focus: Plural agreement inside complex sentences · Theme: Learning and change

Who this lesson is for: For speakers with strong ideas and wide vocabulary who still say 'people has', 'many person' or 'one of the best teacher' when their sentences get long.

Start here

Many Band 6 speakers already have Band 7 vocabulary and Band 7 ideas. What keeps the score down is often one small ending: the -s on a noun or on a verb.

Here is why it matters. Scores of 7, 7, 7 and 6 average 6.75, which rounds up to 7.0. Scores of 7, 7, 7 and 5 average 6.5. One weak criterion costs half a band, so you work on the lowest one.

You probably never make this mistake in short sentences. It hides inside your longest, best sentences, where you are trying hardest. The mistakes in this lesson are ones Band 6 speakers commonly make, and this lesson trains agreement exactly where it breaks.

This is not a knowledge problem — it is a production problem. So everything here is said aloud first. Reading the rule again is the least useful thing you could do.

You need: A phone to record yourself · A timer · A quiet place where you can speak aloud · About 50 minutes

Warm up

Answer each question aloud for about 30 seconds. Just talk — you will check your endings later.

- Who is one of the best teachers you have ever had?
- What is one of the biggest changes in your town in recent years?
- What is one of the most useful subjects you have ever studied?
- What is one of the hardest things about learning English?
- Who is one of your closest friends, and what do you do together?

The rule

> ***The rule:*** *A plural subject takes -s on the noun and no -s on the verb (people have, students like); a singular subject takes no -s on the noun and -s on the verb (a person has, a student likes).*

1. Hear the subject first: one or many? Fix it in your head — people… people… have — and the verb follows.
2. 'One of the…' has two halves. The noun after it is plural: one of the best teachers. The main verb is singular, because the subject is one: one of my friends lives abroad.
3. Inside a that or who clause after 'one of the…', the verb goes back to plural: one of the few subjects that prepare you for work.
4. 'People' is already plural: many people, people have. Never 'many person' or 'people has'.
5. Say the ending loudly enough to hear it. If the examiner cannot hear the -s, it did not happen.

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